

GEOECONOMICS & SECURITY

China's Footprint in the DRC

A consolidated report: who's who, where things are, and how the system works - from the 2008 Sicomines deal to the July 2026 customs crisis. Every chart is checked against open sources; verification status is noted for each section.

How to Read This Report

This document brings together every chart from the database on China's presence in the DRC, with a short caption for each. It opens with a list of key companies (so it's immediately clear who's Chinese, who's DRC state, and who's Western) and two maps (so it's clear where the places mentioned actually are). After that come thematic sections in the same order as the underlying database. The color code is consistent across every chart and map: **red - China**, **blue - the DRC state**, **gray - West/other**.

Chinese Companies and State Entities

CMOC Group (China Molybdenum)	The largest Chinese player in the DRC and the world's largest cobalt producer. Owns 80% of Tenke Fungurume and 71.25% of Kisanfu.
CATL	The world's leading battery maker. Owns 23.75% of Kisanfu through a subsidiary, securing direct access to raw material.
CNMCC (China Nonferrous Metal Mining)	A state corporation. Owns Deziwa (51%) and Kambove (55%) jointly with Gecamines.
Zijin Mining	Owns COMMUS (~70%), a stake in Kamoa-Kakula (39.6%), and 61% of the Manono lithium JV. Ranks in the top 3 for human-rights allegations.
Norinco / Wanbao Mining	A defense conglomerate. Its subsidiary Wanbao owns Pumpi (75%); Norinco itself supplies Sky Dragon 50 air-defense systems to Rwanda.
Sinohydro	A Sicomines shareholder (part of the 68% consortium). Built the Busanga and Zongo II dams.
China Railway Group	A Sicomines shareholder alongside Sinohydro. Named in the Congo Hold-up investigation.
Zhejiang Huayou Cobalt	A major cobalt refiner. Joined the Sicomines consortium following the 2026 audit.
CASC / CATIC	China's state defense-aerospace corporations. Supply CH-4 drones to the DRC army and are negotiating Wing Loong 2 and fighter-jet sales.
CCECC (China Civil Engineering)	Operator of the 30-year TAZARA rail concession (80% stake) - a competitor to the Lobito corridor.
COSCO Shipping	A TAZARA consortium member - handles sea logistics on the route to Dar es Salaam.

DRC State Entities

Gecamines	The DRC's principal state mining company. China's partner in nearly every JV: TFM, Sicomines, Deziwa, Kambove.
Cominiere	The second state mining company. Zijin's partner in the Manono lithium JV.
EGC (Entreprise Generale du Cobalt)	The state monopoly buyer of artisanal cobalt. Finally became operational in 2025-2026 after five years of dormancy.
ARECOMS	The strategic-minerals market regulator. Imposes export quotas and bans on cobalt and concentrates.
SNEL	The state power utility, a partner in several dam projects.
FARDC	The DRC's armed forces - fighting M23 in the east, and receiving Chinese drones.
APCSC	The agency overseeing cooperation agreements like Sicomines; it launched the 2026 audit.

Western and Other Companies

Freeport-McMoRan (US)	Sold TFM (2016) and Kisanfu (2020) to CMOC - the start of China's expansion in the sector.
Glencore (Switzerland/UK)	Owns Mutanda (MUMI) and Kamoto Copper Company (KCC). The world's second-largest cobalt producer.

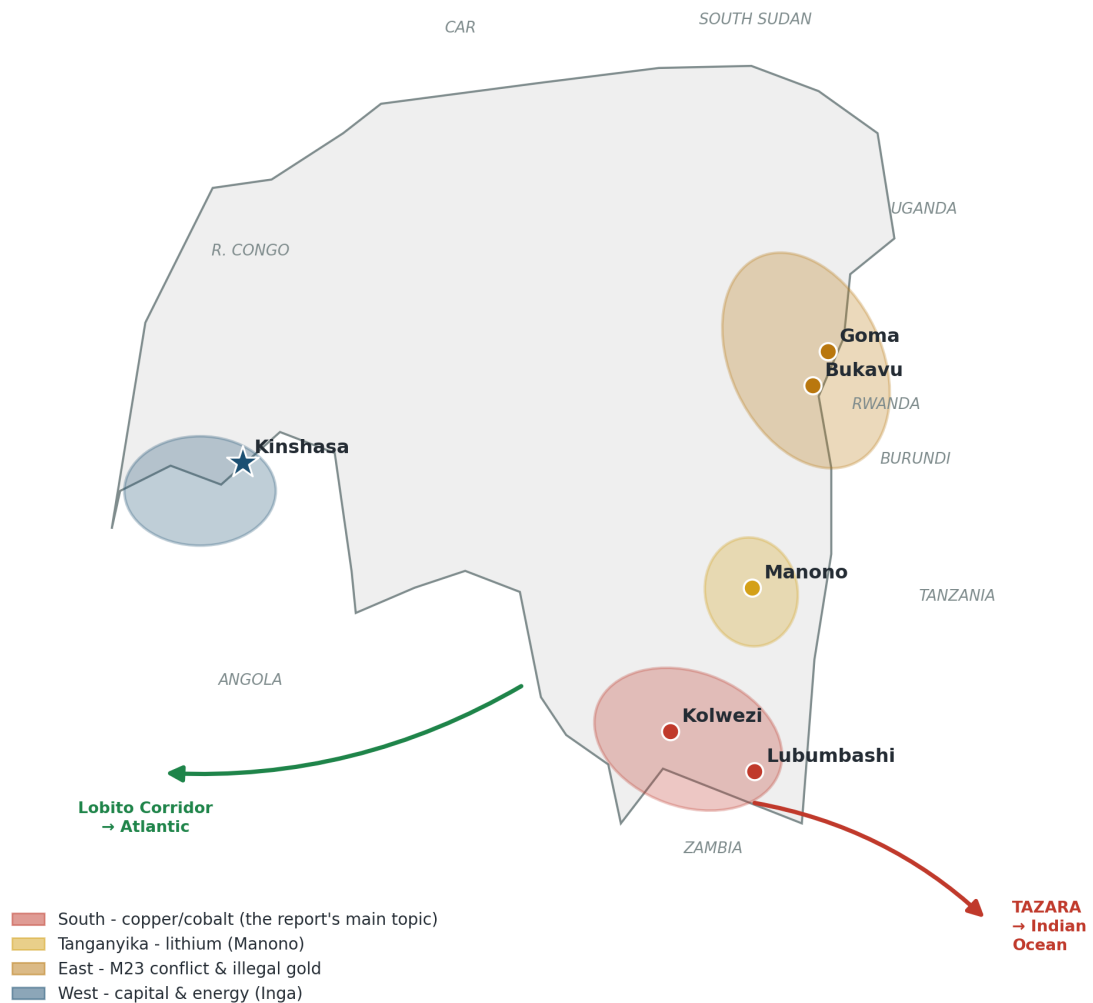
Ivanhoe Mines (Canada)	Zijin's partner in Kamoa-Kakula (39.6%) - the DRC's largest copper complex.
Trafigura (Netherlands/Singapore)	Operator of the Lobito corridor; a trading partner of EGC for artisanal cobalt.
AVZ Minerals (Australia)	Disputing rights to the Manono deposit against the DRC and Zijin at ICSID.
KoBold Metals (US)	AI-driven mineral exploration (backed by Gates and Bezos). Entered a US-brokered framework deal on Manono.
Virtus Minerals (US)	8 employees at the time of the deal. Won rights to Mutoshi under the 'minerals for access' formula (April 2026).
Managem (Morocco)	Minority partner in Pumpi (20%).
ERG - Eurasian Resources Group	Luxembourg-registered, Kazakhstan-linked. Owns Metalkol.
Frontier Services Group / E. Prince	A ~\$700m security contract with the DRC Ministry of Finance for taxes and security in Katanga.
Lloyds Metals and Energy (India)	Bought Chemaf's distressed assets (Mutoshi, Etoile) in 2026, beating out a Chinese bidder.
BGFIBank	A Gabon-Congo bank - the central node of the Congo Hold-up corruption scheme (not a mining company).

How to use this list: whenever a company name appears in a chart or in the text, check the color of the bar to its left in the table - red/blue/gray immediately tells you who it belongs to, without needing to memorize 30 names.

Where This Happens: Maps

Schematic maps for orientation only - not for navigation, GPS accuracy is not guaranteed.

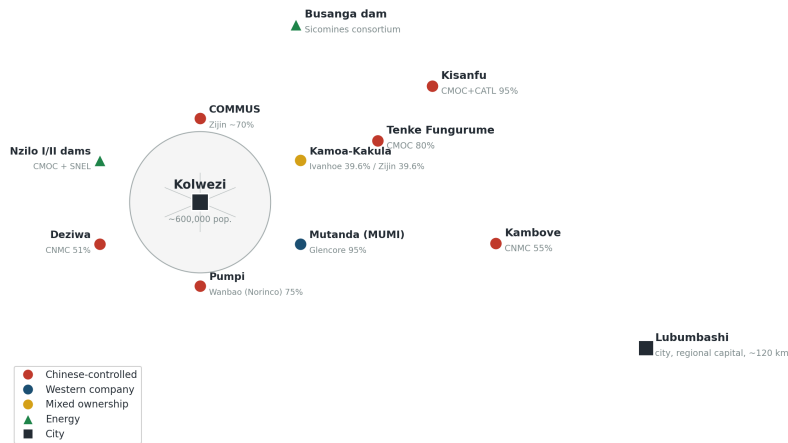
Map 1. The DRC: three zones of the story and two export corridors



Schematic map for orientation only - simplified borders, not for navigation and not geographically precise in detail.

1 Map 1 - the DRC as a whole. The three zones this report is about: the **south** (Lualaba/Katanga - copper and cobalt, the main topic), the **east** (North/South Kivu - the M23 conflict and illegal gold mining), and the **west** (Kinshasa and energy). Tanganyika (Manono - lithium) is marked separately. Arrows show the two competing export corridors.

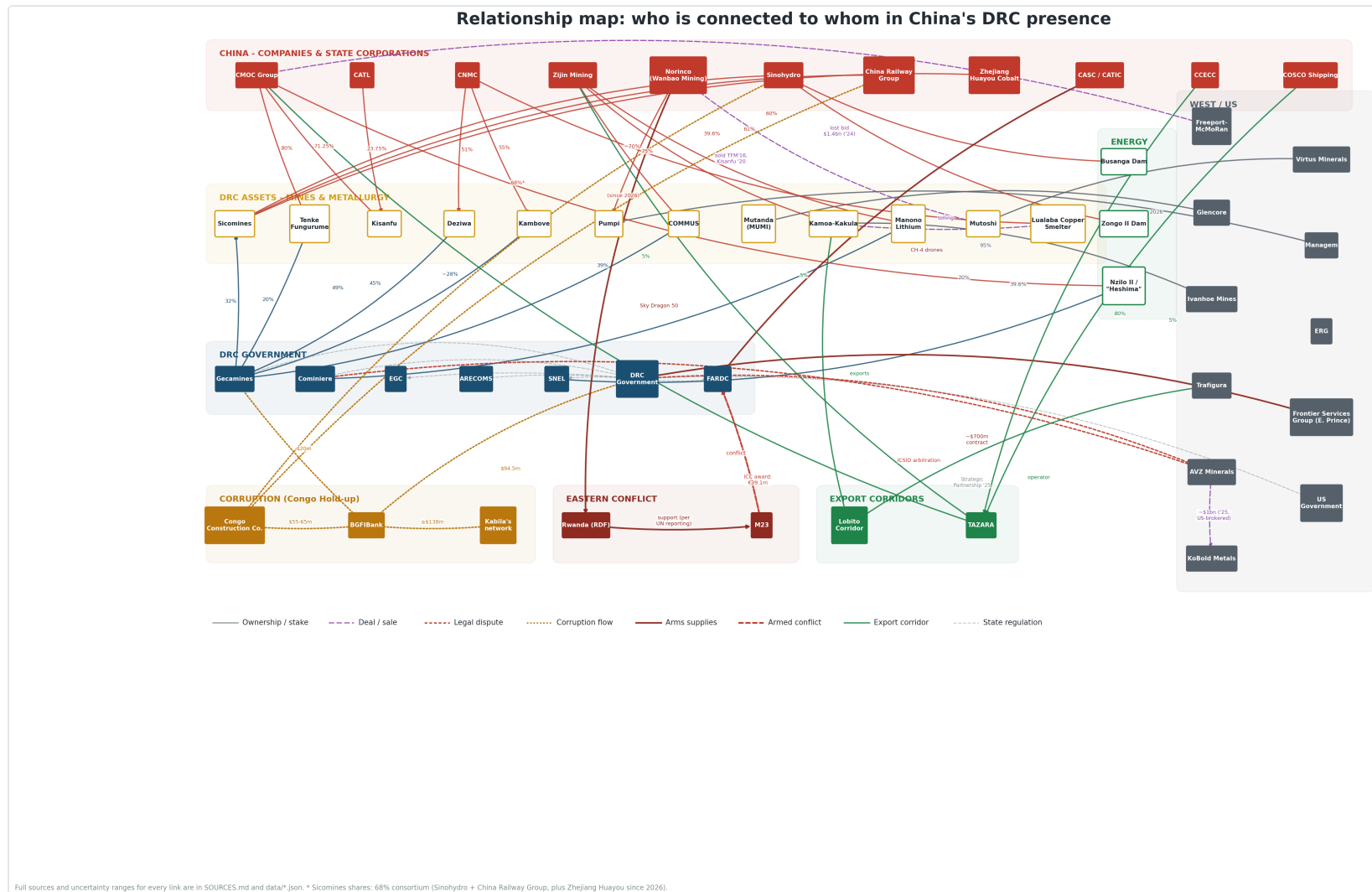
Map 2. The copper-cobalt cluster around Kolwezi (Lualaba)



Schematic: distances between sites near Kolwezi (actually 2-15 km) are enlarged for legibility; not for navigation. Relative positions reconstructed from open descriptions (e.g. "TFM - 110 km northwest of Lubumbashi", "Kisanfu - 33 km from TFM"); exact coordinates are not published by the companies.

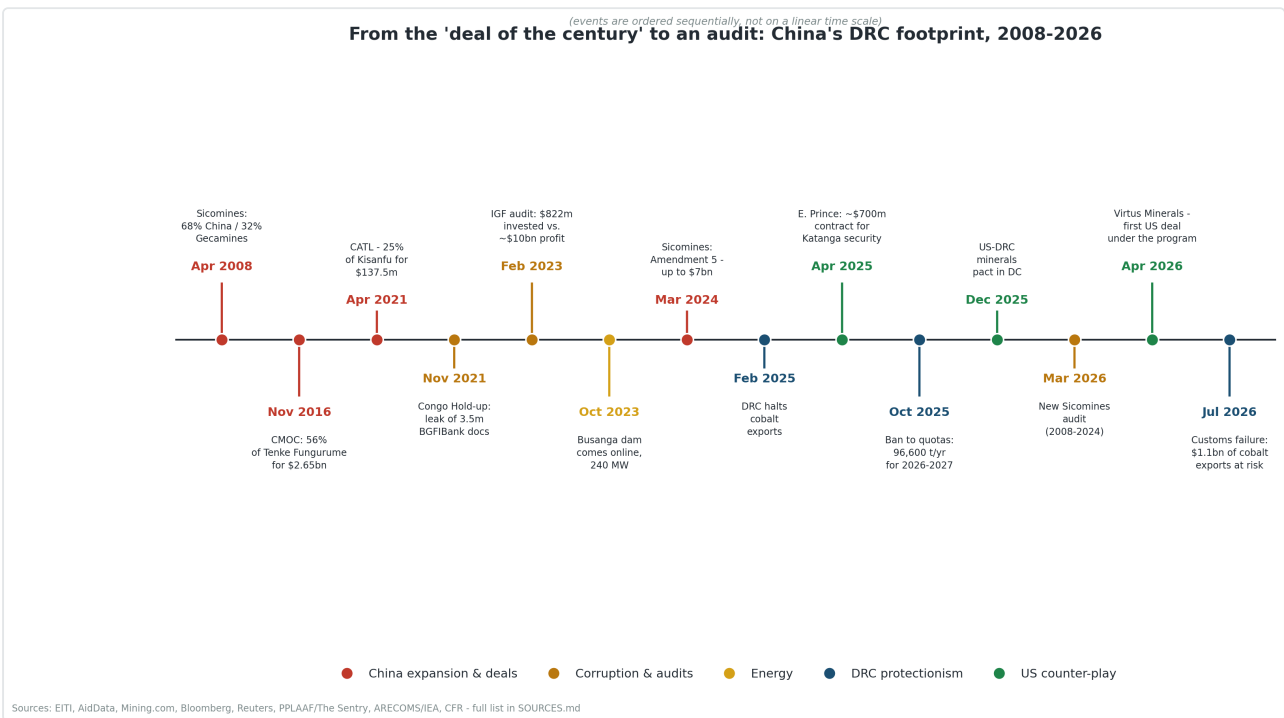
2 Map 2 - the mines around Kolwezi. A close-up of the copper-cobalt belt: who controls what right around Kolwezi and within ~120 km of Lubumbashi. Real distances between neighboring mines (2-15 km) are artificially enlarged for legibility.

Who's Connected to Whom: the Relationship Map



3 The master relationship graph. 51 nodes and 57 edges - ownership, deals, corruption, arms supplies, court cases, and export corridors from every section of the report on a single graph (the edge-type legend is in the lower right). Full resolution (5400×3500 px) - in charts/17_master_network_graph.png in the repository.

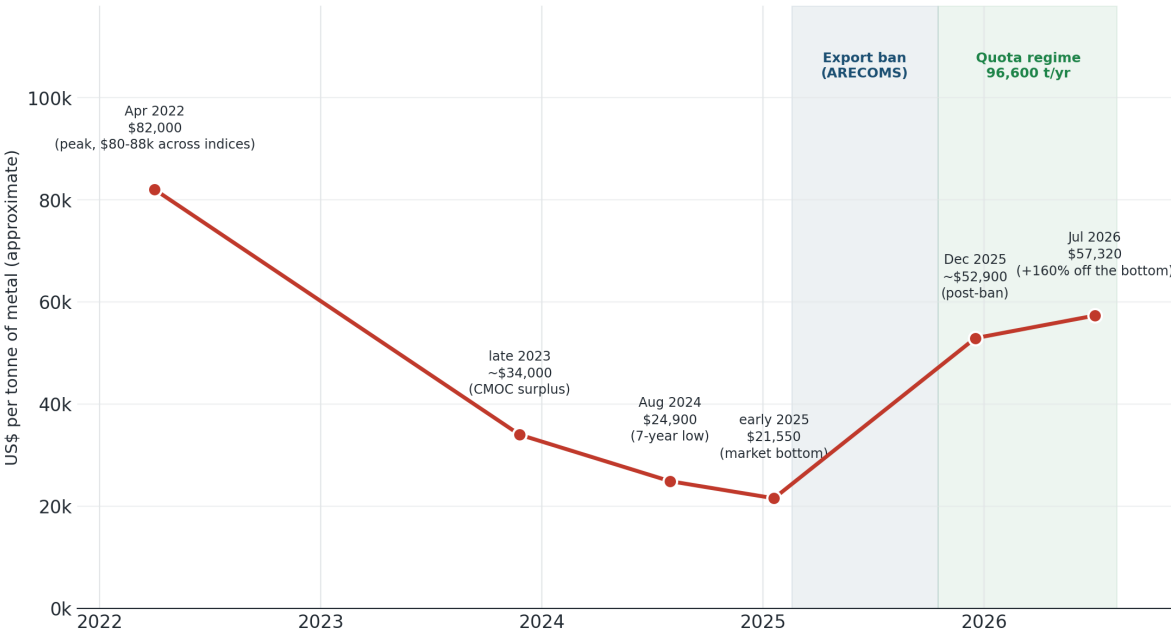
Timeline, 2008-2026



4 From the deal of the century to an audit. The full timeline of China's presence in the DRC on a single scale. **Key observation:** events sharply accelerate after 2023 - this isn't a gradual process, it's an accelerating pushback by DRC and US regulators against a Chinese expansion model that had been settled for over a decade.

Cobalt Market: Dumping and Protectionism

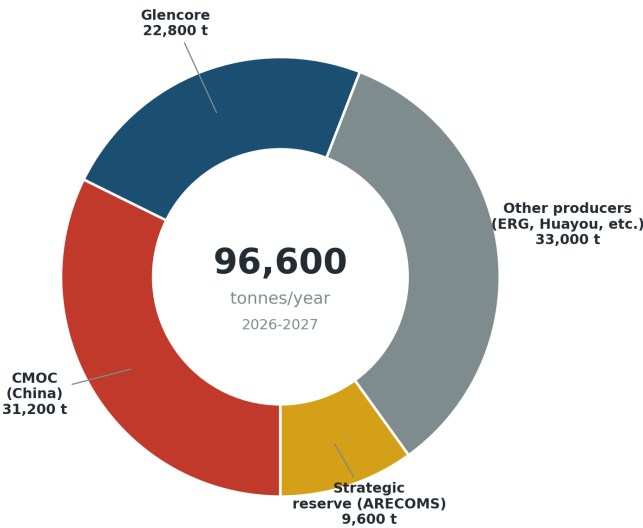
The cobalt seesaw: how the DRC turned the market against China's dumping



Sources: Cobalt Institute, Fastmarkets, S&P Global, IEA/ARECOMS, Reuters, MiningWeekly, Evidencity - an approximate trend across different price indices, not a single continuous series.

5 Cobalt price, 2022-2026. The price collapsed roughly 4x as CMOC ramped up output (2022-2025), then rose 160% after the DRC halted exports in February 2025. **Takeaway:** when the market can't stop dumping, a regulator can.

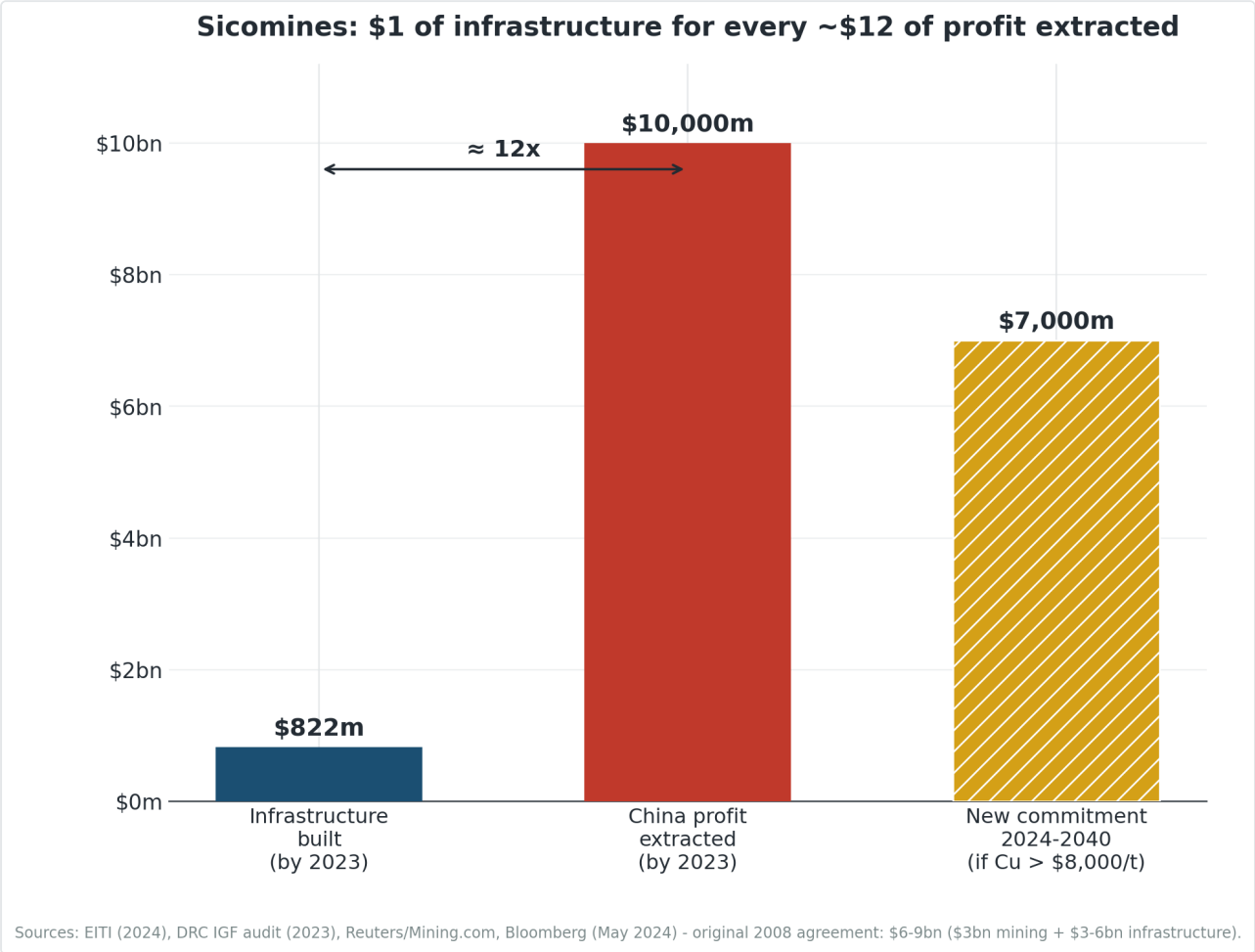
How the DRC quotas cobalt exports



Sources: ARECOMS (Decision No. 004/2025), IEA Policy Database, GreenStocksResearch/IEA Global Critical Minerals Outlook 2026, Reuters - 2026 company quotas; the 87,000t base quota is allocated pro rata to historical exports.

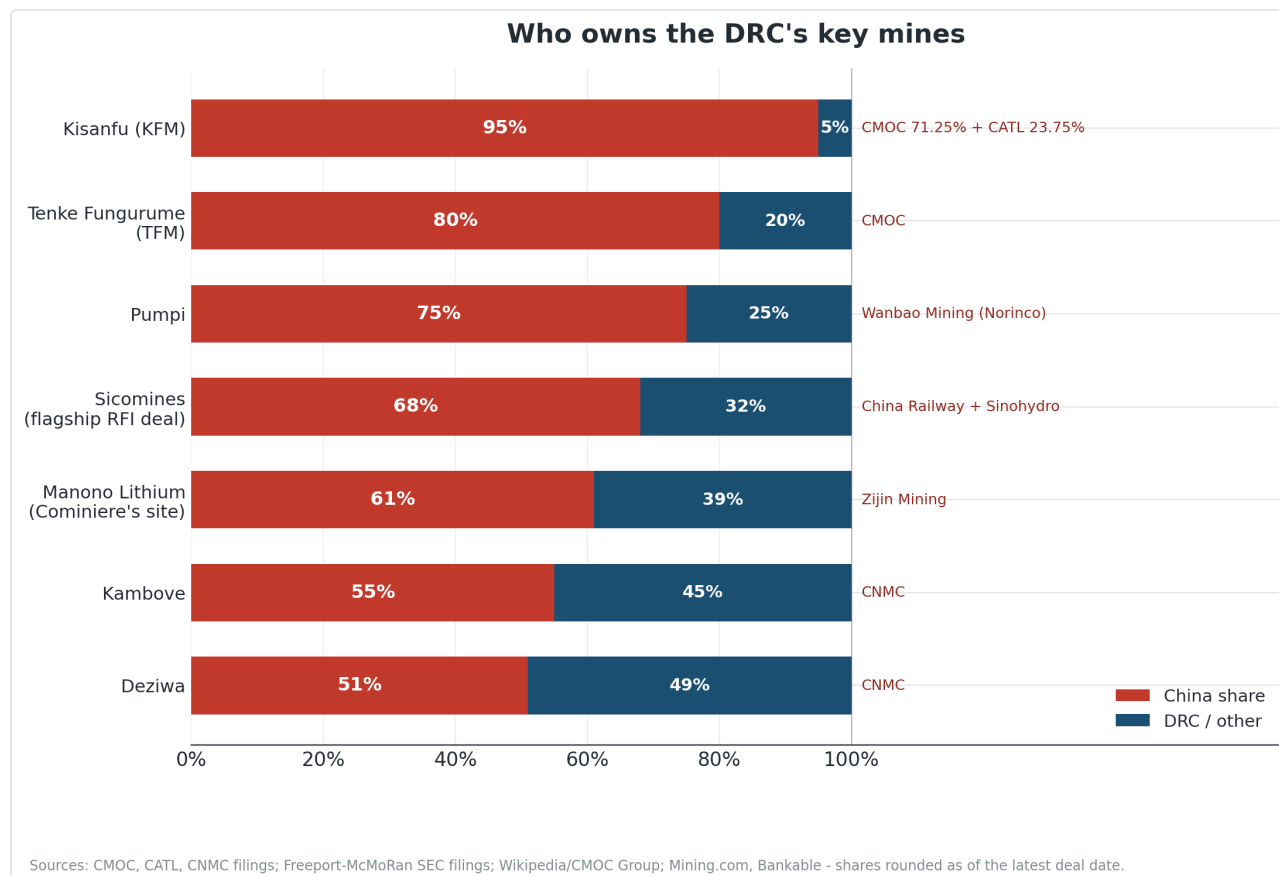
6 The export quota, 2026-2027. Since October 2025 a cap of 96,600 t/year has been in force - less than half of 2024's volume. Shown here is how that quota splits between the largest exporters and the state's strategic reserve.

Sicomines: Anatomy of the Deal of the Century



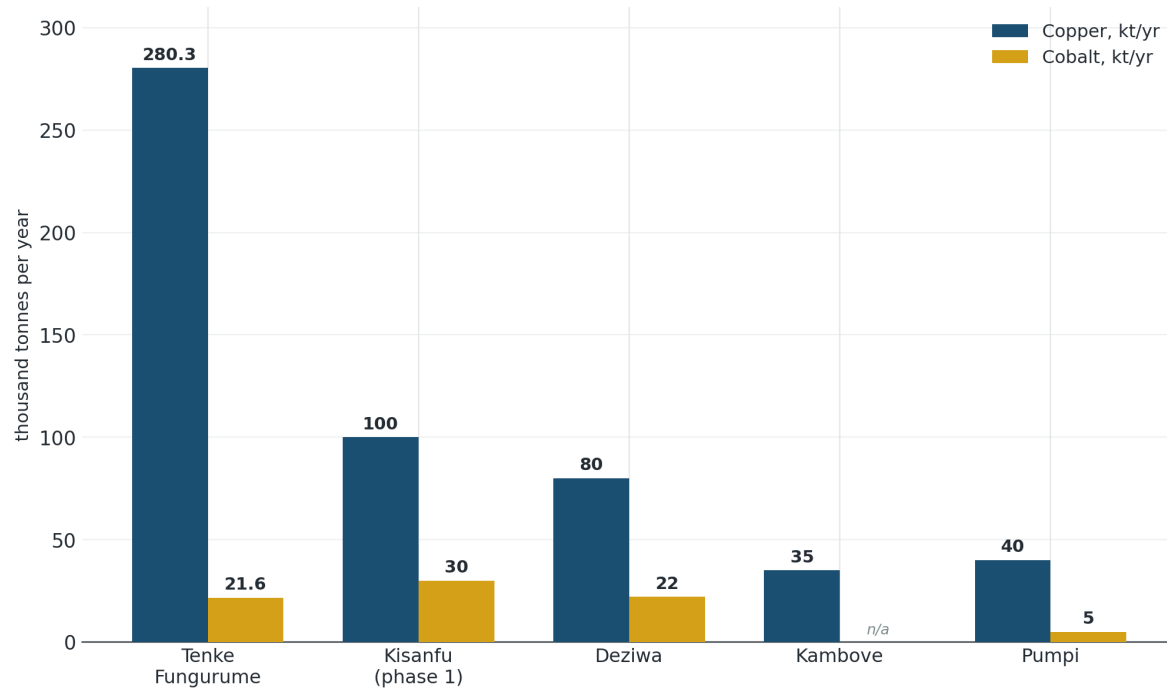
7 Infrastructure vs. profit. For every dollar of infrastructure built under the 2008 deal, China extracted roughly **\$12 in profit**. The yellow bar is the new 2024-2040 commitment (\$7bn), only partly delivered so far.

Mining: Who Owns What



8 Ownership by project. China-linked capital's share across seven flagship projects - from 51% (Deziwa) to 95% (Kisanfu). In none of the seven does DRC/partner capital exceed China's.

Output at China's DRC mines (2022-2023 snapshot)

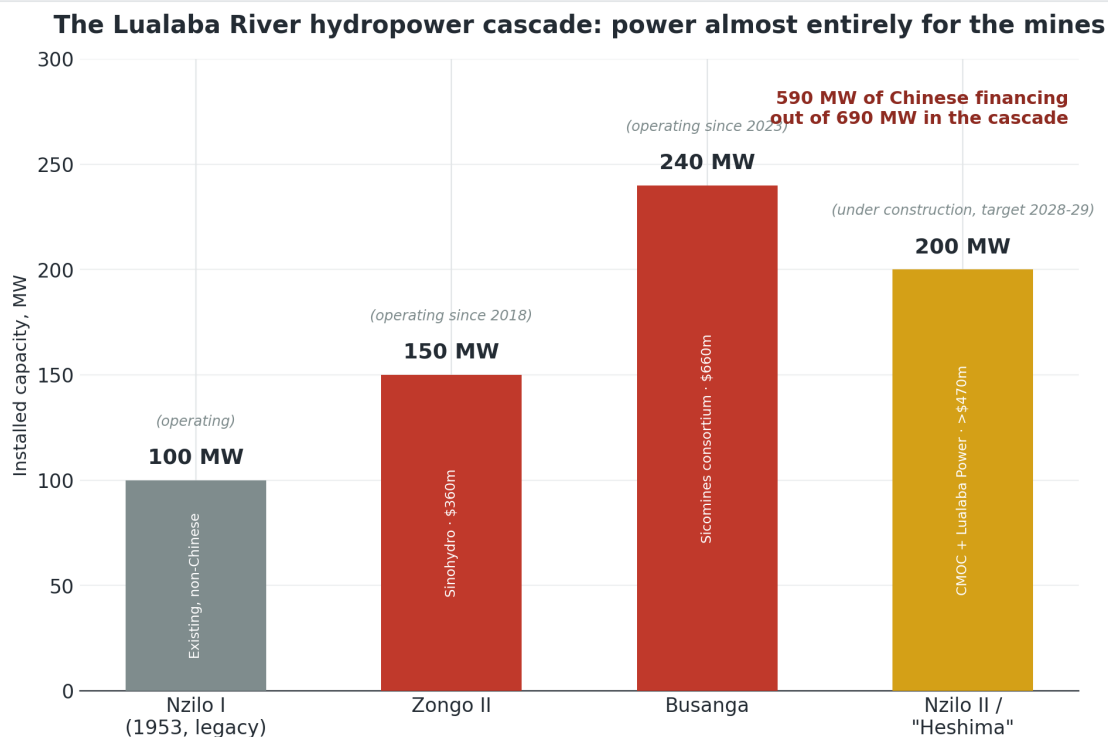


TFM + KFM (CMOC) alone had grown to a combined 741.1kt of copper and 117.5kt of cobalt per year by 2025

Sources: CMOC/CNMC/Wanbao Mining corporate reporting, Cobalt Institute, CSIS - Kambove: cobalt figures were not published separately.

9 Production by project. Copper and cobalt output at five projects (2022-2023 snapshot). TFM is the clear leader by volume; by 2025 CMOC's combined totals had grown even further (see the chart's own annotation).

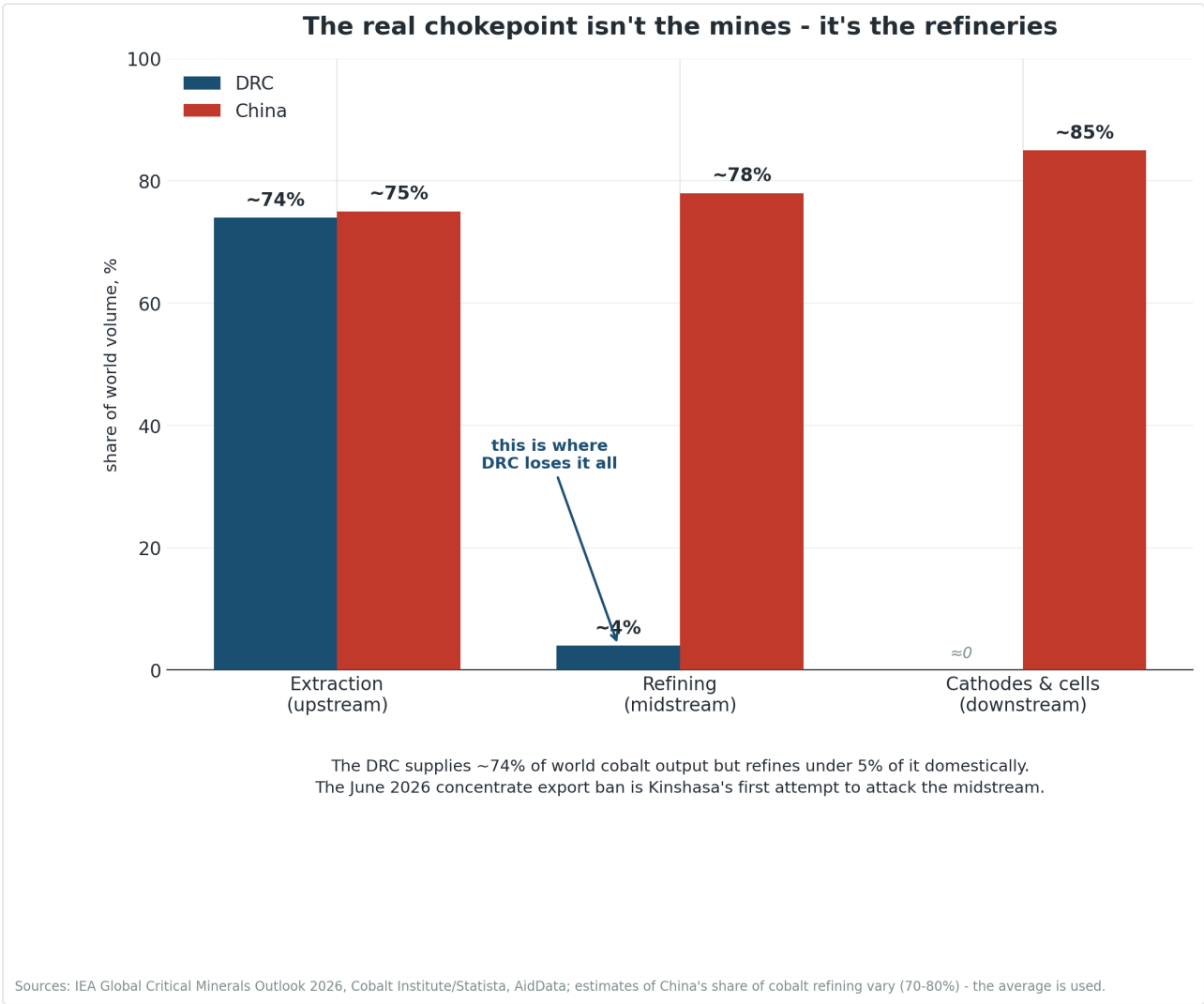
Energy: Dams Built for the Mines



Sources: AidData (China Eximbank), Wikipedia (Zongo II), Herbert Smith Freehills / CMOC press releases, Bankable Africa - Busanga: up to 170 MW is directly reserved for Sicomines.

10 The Lualaba River dam cascade. Three of the four stations were built with Chinese money (590 of the cascade's 690 MW) and mostly power the mines rather than the region's homes.

The Market's Real Chokepoint

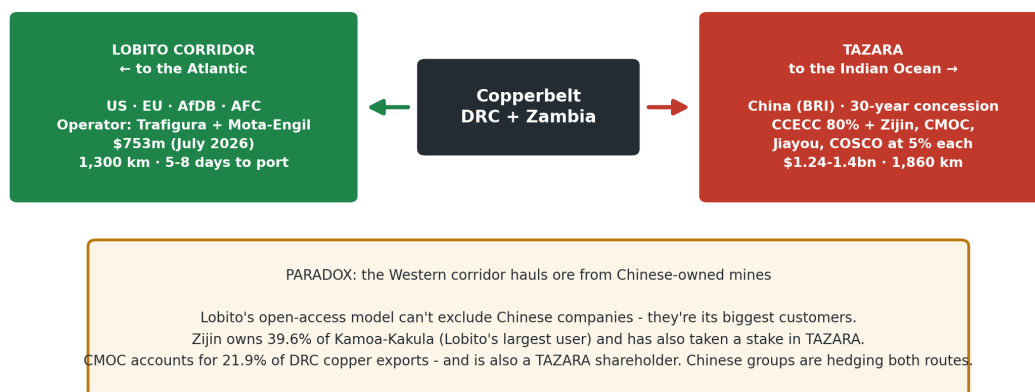


11 Extraction vs. refining. The most important chart in this report. The DRC supplies ~74% of world cobalt output but refines under 5% of it. The real power over the market isn't in the mine - it's in the refinery, and the refinery is Chinese.

Export Corridors

Two corridors, one ore

Competition has shifted from 'who owns the mines' to 'who controls the routes'



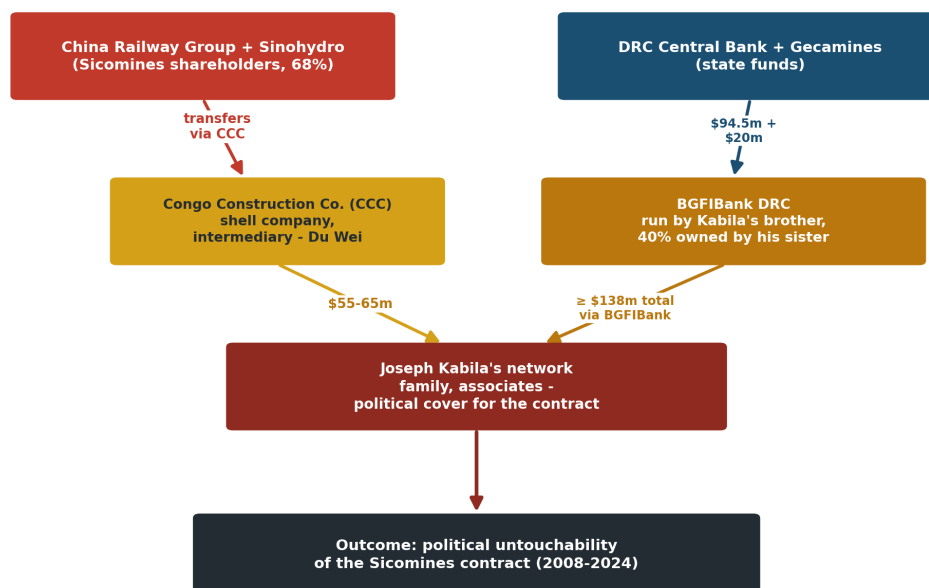
Sources: Reuters/Ecofin Agency (2026-04), OECD Background Note, ORF, Veracity Worldwide, Africa Finance Corporation, bne IntelliNews, S&P Global.

12 Lobito vs. TAZARA. Two competing routes: the Western Lobito corridor (US/EU, to the Atlantic) and the eastern TAZARA line (China, to the Indian Ocean). **Paradox:** the Western corridor's biggest customer is a mine with a Chinese co-owner (Zijin in Kamoa-Kakula).

Corruption: the Congo Hold-up Case

Congo Hold-up: how an offshore bank protected the deal of the century

Reconstructed from the leak of 3.5 million BGFIBank documents (PPLAAF, Mediapart, The Sentry, EIC, 19 media outlets + 5 NGOs, 2021)



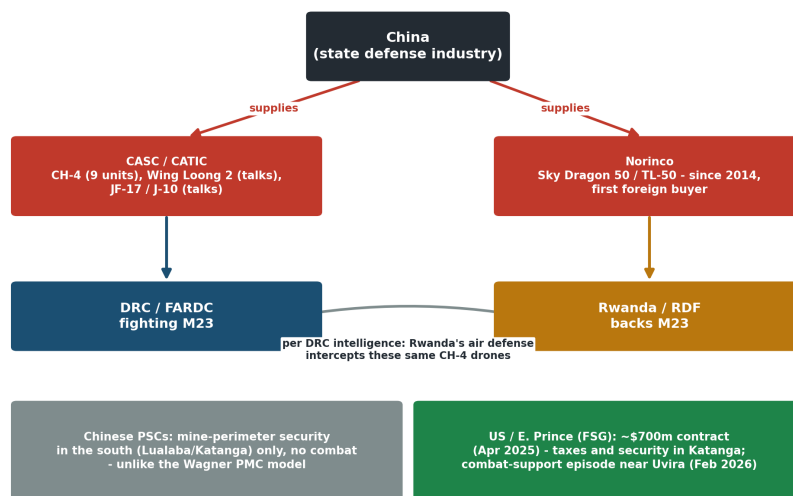
Sources: The Sentry ('The Backchannel', 2021), PPLAAF, Mediapart, Al Jazeera, L'Orient Today - amounts for individual branches of the scheme vary across reports (\$55-65m for CCC); full list in SOURCES.md.

13 The money flow. Reconstructed from a leak of 3.5 million documents: money from the Chinese consortium and from the DRC state itself flowed through a single bank (BGFIBank) to former president Kabila's network - buying two decades of political untouchability for the Sicomines contract.

The Military Dimension

Beijing's 'dual diplomacy' and the private-security market in the DRC

Arms to both sides of the conflict - and a parallel market of foreign PMCs around minerals



Sources: Military Africa, The Diplomat, DefenceWeb, armyrecognition.com, ORF, Reuters/Geeska, Friends of the Congo, africansecurityanalysis.com - details on drone interception rely on DRC intelligence reports and are not independently verified.

14 'Dual diplomacy' and the security market. China supplies arms to both sides of the eastern conflict - drones to the DRC army, air-defense systems to Rwanda. Below that, a parallel private-security market, including American Erik Prince's contract.

Who actually guards China's assets in the DRC

Not the PLA, and not a 'second Wagner' - state-licensed PSCs, plus hiring FARDC itself

PSCs confirmed to be operating in the DRC

DeWe Security Service

Founded 2011. The most visible. Operates in the DRC, Cameroon, Chad, Nigeria, Djibouti, Ethiopia. 352 full-time staff abroad + ~3,000 local hires (globally).

Huaxin Zhong An Security Group

One of 3 companies licensed to carry weapons abroad. Specializes in maritime escort + facility security.

Shandong Huawei/Haiwei Security

Per the Africa Center, specializes specifically in guarding Chinese mines in southern Africa.

China Security Technology, VSS Security

In Sudan/South Sudan they accompany local forces on operations - the most 'permissive' model.

Scale in context

20 of 5,000

Chinese PSCs are licensed to work abroad

14 African countries

Including the DRC - where Chinese PSCs operate

35,000+

DeWe + Huaxin Zhong An contractors across 50 countries

> 2,500

more than the PLA's entire personnel on the continent (peacekeepers + the Djibouti base)

\$10bn/year

spent by Chinese state companies on security worldwide

0

PLA bases in the DRC; the PLA's only overseas base in Africa is in Djibouti

Documented incidents around facility security

2019-06

- TFM: ~10,000 artisanal miners forcibly evicted (Amnesty Int'l)

2021-07

- COMMUS/Zijin, Kolwezi: 2 miners beaten by guards - video went viral

2021-11

- Gold mine, east: 2 Chinese + a Congolese woman + a Ugandan killed, 10 missing

2023-09

- Ambush in Lamba, Fizi (S. Kivu): 2 Chinese, 1 Ghanaian, 1 FARDC soldier killed

2023-10

- Attack on a gold concession in Fizi: site security was provided by FARDC, not a PSC

2018-2025

- AFREWATCH: ≥35 cases of violence against miners near mine perimeters

Why there's no 'second Wagner' in the DRC

The non-interference doctrine remains diplomatically valuable for Beijing

Risk of neo-colonialism accusations - the number of human-rights complaints is already rising (434 allegations over 2021-25, see the human-rights track)

The model already works through control of processing and capital, not military control of territory

BUT: the 26 May 2026 China-DRC police cooperation agreement is shifting the threshold toward policing and law enforcement

Sources: Carnegie Endowment, Africa Center for Strategic Studies, Military Africa, Grey Dynamics, VOA, Atlas Institute, AFREWATCH, Amnesty International, Mining.com, Copperbelt Katanga Mining, SCMP. Full links in SOURCES.md.

15 Who actually guards the assets. The answer is shorter than you'd expect: not the PLA. China has fewer formal troops in the DRC than contractors from licensed PSCs like DeWe Security - and part of the security burden in the east is outsourced to FARDC itself, confirmed at the site of the October 2023 Fizi attack.

What Residents Themselves Say

What Congolese Residents Themselves Say

Named, on-the-record voices gathered by journalists and NGOs — the closest available proxy for grassroots opinion

GRIEVANCES

Pierre

Resident, Noa village, copper-cobalt belt

"We live in an environment that brings us more problems than solutions."

Jean Marc Kananga Muleba

Resident, Kolwezi

Says finding a new home with power and water is unimaginable on the ~\$7,500 paid per demolished house.

Adelard Makonga

Resident, Tshabula village, Kolwezi

Refused a cash payout, held out for a proper legal relocation from COMMUS (Zijin).

Edmond Chansa, 60

Displaced resident, Kolwezi

Regrets his new living conditions after being relocated for a COMMUS quarry.

Unnamed mother

Kolwezi, reacting to a beating of diggers filmed on camera

Says she was deeply shocked to see her compatriots treated so inhumanely; has already gone to the courts.

Ghislain Chivundu Mutalemba

Commander, local mining brigade, Kamituga, South Kivu

"On contrôle difficilement ces sociétés." ("These companies are hard to keep tabs on.")

Hilaire Isombya

Civil-society coordinator, Mwenga, South Kivu

Argues Chinese-linked mining activity has itself become a source of local insecurity.

CIVIL SOCIETY & COUNTERPOINTS

CNPAV coalition

"Congo Is Not for Sale"

Sicomines tax breaks cost the treasury \$132m in 2024; below \$8,000/t copper, DRC "will receive less, or even nothing."

South Kivu parliamentary commission

Formally found six Chinese firms guilty of illegal gold/cassiterite mining in Mwenga, shielded by local cooperatives, polluting rivers with mining chemicals.

Amnesty International + IBGDH

Joint press conference, Lubumbashi, 2025

Condemned forced evictions in Kolwezi carried out for mining expansion without resettlement plans or fair compensation.

Zhu Jing

Then-Chinese Ambassador to the DRC, on Twitter, 2021

Warned the DRC "must not become the battleground for great powers."

Aaron Chen

GM Operations, MMG Kinsevere (China Minmetals), at Cobalt Institute congress

Publicly demanded Kinshasa clarify its cobalt quota rules, calling his firm's allocation insufficient and damaging.

Chinese Embassy in DRC

Official public messaging, 2024-2026

Consistently frames ties as "win-win" modernization and deep friendship dating to the independence era.

AFROBAROMETER (continent-wide, not DRC-specific)

~60-66% of Africans surveyed across 34-36 countries call China's influence "positive" (vs. 13-14% negative) — similar to the US. But most who know of Chinese loans worry their country has borrowed too much, and the US still edges out China as preferred development model.

Sources: Mongabay, RAID ("Beneath the Green"), VOA Afrique, Actualite.cd, Anadolu Agency, AIAfrica, France24 Observers, AFREWATCH, SCMP, Le Blog Auto, Chinese Embassy in DRC, Afrobarometer. Full citations and methodology caveats in data/public_sentiment.json and SOURCES.md.

16

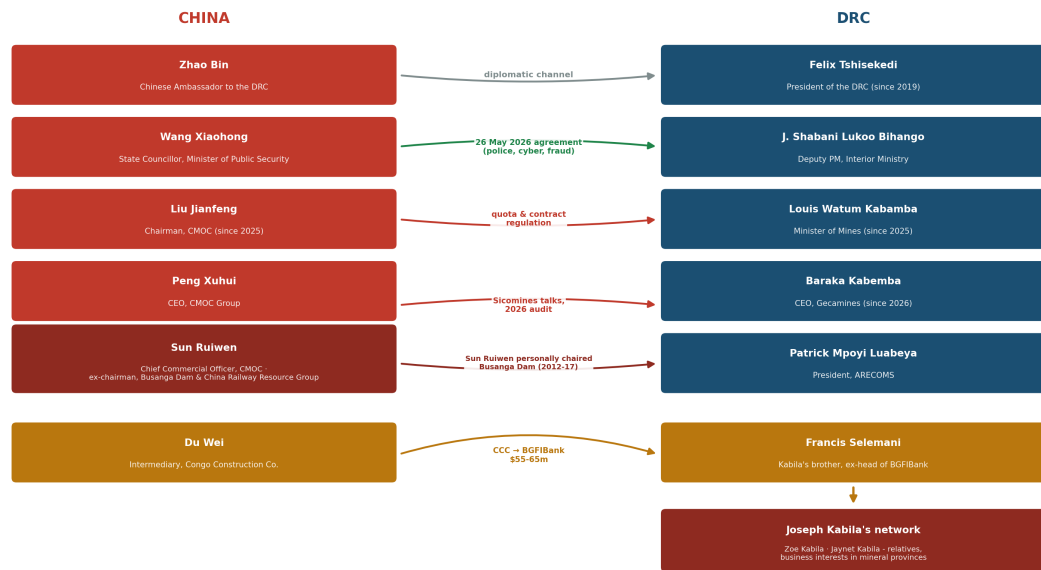
Named voices from the ground.

Everything else in this report is filings, data, and journalism. This is different: on-the-record testimony from Congolese residents and civil society, plus continent-wide polling for context. A live public 'forum' specific to this topic barely exists in searchable form, so journalist-mediated testimony is the closest available proxy - read it as opinion and testimony, not verified fact.

Who's Who: the People

Who's who: the people on both sides

Current and historical figures - diplomats, executives, ministers, the corruption network



HISTORY: FROM SIGNING TO DEATH SENTENCE

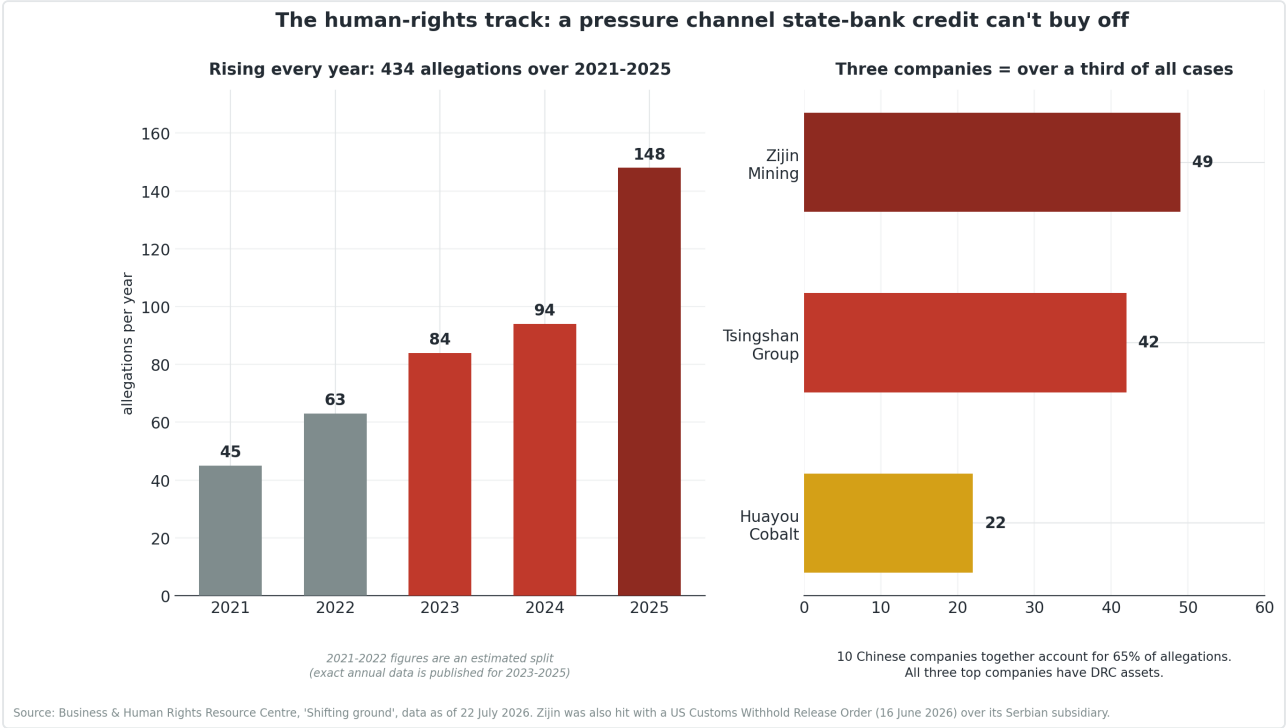


Muzito signed the deal as PM (2008) - today, as Tshisekedi's budget minister, he publicly calls its result 'zero for the country'. Yuma and Pakabomba have been replaced by successors oriented toward reworking ties with China and partnering with the US (Kabemba, Watum Kabamba).

Sources and a status breakdown for each figure (fact / allegation / one party's claim) are in data/key_people.json and SOURCES.md. Positions current as of August 2026.

17 21 figures on both sides. Companies are an abstraction; real people negotiate and take the bribes. From Ambassador Zhao Bin and CMOC's leadership to Adolphe Muzito - the prime minister who signed Sicominex in 2008 and became its sharpest critic. Every fact/allegation's status is flagged in data/key_people.json.

The Human-Rights Track



18 Allegations against Chinese projects. The number of allegations rises every year; three companies (Zijin, Tsingshan, Huayou) account for more than a third of all cases. This is a pressure channel that state-bank credit can't buy off.

Trade and the "Two Chinas"

The closed loop: copper leaves as raw material, comes back as product

A snapshot of May 2026 - one month of DRC-China bilateral trade



The DRC runs a trade surplus (\$1.62bn/month) - which is exactly why it doesn't see the problem
The surplus is built on low-value-added raw material. The batteries and transformers it imports are made from that same Congolese metal - just with someone else's value added.

Source: OEC (oec.world), Chinese General Administration of Customs data for May 2026; annual context - China-Global South Project.

19 The closed trade loop. One month (May 2026): the DRC sold China \$2.28bn of copper and bought back \$663m of batteries and transformers - made from that same copper, but now with someone else's value added.

Two Chinas in Congo

State corporations in Katanga and freelance gold miners in the east - not one strategy, but two unrelated ones

KATANGA (south) **SOUTH KIVU (east)**

Mineral	copper and cobalt	gold
Provinces	Lualaba, Haut-Katanga	South Kivu, Ituri
Actor type	CMOC, Zijin, CNMC - state corporations	hundreds of small private firms
Legal status	official concessions, contracts	skirting the law via cooperatives
Scale	a few dozen large projects	147-547+ firms, estimates vary
Beijing's response	diplomatic defense of the deals	the MFA itself orders a shutdown
Kinshasa's response	audits, contract renegotiation	arrests, trials, provincial suspensions
Landmark event	Sicomines Amendment 5, 2024	first brokers sentenced - 7 years, 2025

Sources: VOA, AP, Africa Defense Forum, IFRI, Business & Human Rights Centre, Copperbelt Katanga Mining - estimates of the number of firms in South Kivu vary by year and source (147-547+).

20 Katanga vs. South Kivu. Organized state corporations in the south, and hundreds of small, often-illegal gold operators in the east - two different, unrelated Chinese strategies within one country.

Full Data and Source Verification

This PDF is a showcase. Every figure, every uncertainty range, and a verification status (confirmed / clarified / diverges / not re-verified) for every claim are in the 19 data/*.json files and in SOURCES.md in the database repository. The code for every chart (matplotlib) is in scripts/, and can be re-run as new data becomes available.